

Free-dumb!

WITH THE COMING OF THE INTERNET, ALSO CAME RESENTMENT OF IT BY PEOPLE IN POWER,

because it gave common people the two most dangerous tools – a platform, and anonymity. There's a reason why authoritarian states like China and North Korea have such rigid control over the internet access of their people. In Europe and America, however, where the masses have freedom (or at least the illusion of it), such control over the internet is not possible. Of course the powerful want to control the internet, but until the big social media companies arose, there was no way to control it.

Twitter, under pressure to do something, went ahead and banned all forms of political advertising on its platform. It got a lot of praise for doing so, from those not in the know, obviously. Facebook on the other hand came out in January 2020 with a decision to not ban or even fact check any political ad whatsoever. With all sides of political discourse blaming every other side of spreading false information, many felt that Facebook should have gone the way of Twitter.

Seriously, did anyone really expect Facebook to follow suit? Twitter is losing an estimated \$3 million in election ads, while even conservative estimates for the amount Facebook earns from political ads put it at \$300 million! In essence, this was a PR campaign for Twitter, and a way to pile pressure on Facebook, and get even more people to hate Facebook and like Twitter. Not bad at all for a mere \$3 million in losses!

Obviously, Facebook is doubling down on \$300 million, hoping to grow that figure, and is doing so hoping that its users will see the act of not blocking anything as Facebook upholding free speech. But it's not freedom, it's free-dumb that they're selling. Under pressure for the content on it, Facebook already deletes stuff all the time, in terms of comments, videos and images made as posts by users, and does so in a very inconsistent manner. Often a mildly offensive joke will get deleted, while literal racists proclaiming their supremacy and calling those of darker skin colours inferior get left alone! Thus, Facebook isn't supporting free speech for you and me, only free advertising by politicians and the companies that support them. Of course this is all about money... why wouldn't it be? What about any of these companies has ever suggested there would be anything but money driving them?

Carefully worded statements show that they're both leaving themselves wiggle room... Twitter is leaving "exceptions" to the ban, though we're

not sure what those exceptions are, and they're also lumping in other things under the ban. Jack Dorsey even said they would block ads about climate change, healthcare, immigration, national security, taxes and more! Facebook on the other hand is not committing to allowing just anything to be advertised. For example, party X could take out ads that falsely claim that party Y was doing something that would anger Y's loyal following. That seems to be allowed, but if party Y took out an ad targeting party X's followers, telling them the election day was one day later than the actual date, that Zuckerberg said Facebook would block. So it's not as black and white as these two companies are making it appear.

Incidentally, the real problem with social media isn't ads. It's the content itself being fake, and that's being forgotten about in this whole drama. Twitter, for example, has pathetic ad revenues from political parties, because the way to game twitter is not to spend money on ads, but to spend money on retweet farms, bot farms and more, to game the system by using fake accounts to affect the trending lists on the platform. They have a flawed system that's already being misused, and they're not really doing much to solve the issues.

Advertising is how Facebook survives, especially from boosted posts, which often may not appear directly political, but actually are. For example, boosting videos by a scientist with dubious credentials making claims about climate change being fake, are obviously helping one side of the political spectrum, and not another. And yes, fake users can also falsely game Facebook's virality system, but it's not even close to Twitter's problems with bots.

Logically, keeping fake accounts off their platforms is the best thing they can do to improve the quality of the content. That's not just my opinion, that's Elon Musk's opinion as well, when asked how he'd improve Twitter. Instead of dragging their feet with verifications, they should be handing out blue verified ticks by the boatload! They should be pushing verifications by limiting post reach of non-verified users. That's one way to ensure that the fake users and bots on their platforms are reduced. But do they want to? They say they do, and yet here we are, still talking about fake accounts in 2020! Can you spot an easter egg I've hidden in this article, that suggests a solution to this nonsense? First one to spot it and write in wins a mystery gift! 



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